Incredible India

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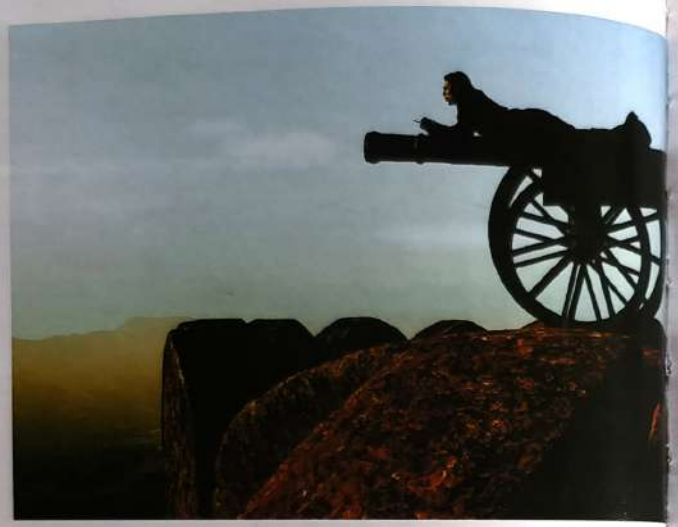
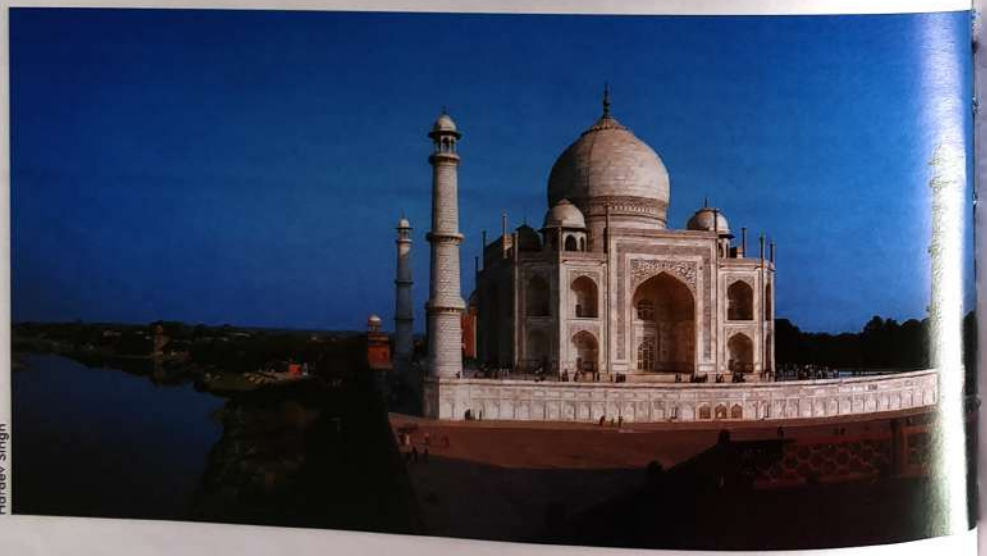
Indian design is poised at an interesting crossroad, integrating with the world and fast evolving as an industry to reckon with, writes Chitra Balasubramaniam, a seasoned writer on design and crafts



Siddharth Mishra

Rajesh Mishra

Towards new horizons



Hardev Singh

Indian design and craft techniques have been like a huge sponge absorbing, adapting, integrating and amalgamating the cross-cultural influences over centuries. Trade and political conquests brought cultural nuances, varied lifestyle, tradition and design sensibilities, which soon took root in the country. Assimilating these influences, Indian design evolved developing a sense of its own. In an environment where hand skills were predominant, the techniques and skills of the Indian craftsman rose to great heights. The Chola bronzes of the 10th century show a rare understanding of the process of metallurgy, which still confounds metallurgists. The wood carvings found on stone carved temples, be it the Konark temple or the Chidambaram or Meenakshi temples, bring together a fine synthesis of architecture and design.

ABOVE: Potpourri Ball, in wood and steel from Sogani's *Atmos-sphere* collection

TOP RIGHT: Atul Sinha's harp in the shape of a woman's face - the gold leaf accentuates the harp's strings

RIGHT: The coveted *Samsung Trophy* designed by Vibhor Sogani, symbolising peace

FACING PAGE:
TOP: Canon created by Atul Sinha. Drawing inspiration from canons of the bygone era, it was made by a local metal worker. The highlight is the surface treatment, with its nice sheen. The canon was handcrafted using an amalgam of three metals - copper, brass and tin, which also gives it the three distinct tones. A very contemporary piece created using some very basic craft skills

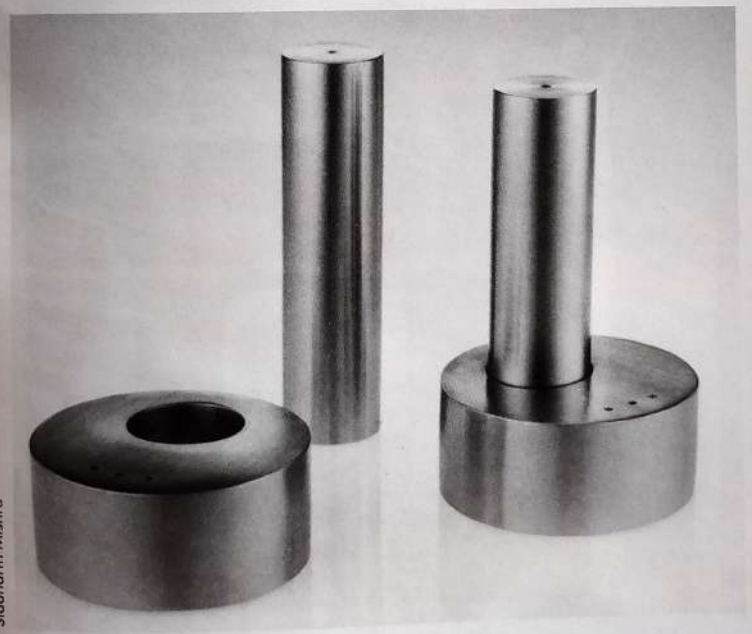
BELOW: Poem in marble combining design and craftsmanship

Siddharth Mishra

Bimla Verma

And the epitome of such design and craftsmanship is the Taj Mahal, which still stands tall in its glory. The pietra durra work on the walls is said to be the finest such example of the craft and captures the essence of design during Mughal period. The beautiful gold work in Usta tradition done on the walls of the Kwaja Moinuddin Chisti's tomb, has an innate characteristic to it, though the technique came from Iran. Today, Indian design is poised at an interesting crossroad. And like history repeating itself, it is absorbing the trends and styles in the global market in a bid to integrate itself with the world and evolve as an industry. This is all the more evident in the lifestyle segment. Imported lifestyle products have meant greater exposure to design sensibilities, quality and finish, as per international standards. Combination of these with the repertoire of Indian design and craft techniques presents vast untapped opportunities. In certain sections of the industry Indian designers have made their presence felt as is the case of Dilip Chabbria with DC Designs, who has put Indian automobile design on the world map or Michael Foley as head of design department at Titan Industries, which created the slimmest watch in the world. Vibhor Sogani, designer, the latest of which is the Samsung Trophy for the Indo-Pak series says, "There has been change in the last three years, which we have not felt earlier. There is greater visibility now and one can see a lot more design."

Indian design, which was previously characterised by the ethnic, excessively ornate and the fully decorative, is now leaning towards the minimal, with more

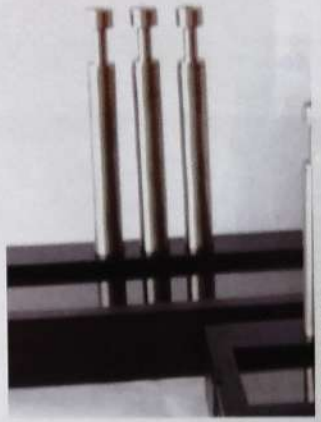


Siddharth Mishra

ABOVE: Inlay work on marble - a utility plate

LEFT: A salt and pepper shaker in steel by Vibhor Sogani

Siddharth Mishra



Siddharth Mishra

Rajesh Mishra

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: A service tray from Sogani's *Blue Moon* series; Contemporary packaging for traditional *ittars* by Vibhor Sogani; *Shakti* by Atul Sinha; *Usta* work on a leather Kupi

contemporary pieces. Much innovation is being seen in the works by bell metal casters, dokra artisans who use the lost wax method and bastar crafts of iron. What is interesting is that the new genre of products designed seeks to combine Indian sensibility and essence to create a utilitarian product. Sogani adds, "The craft sector is a gold mine, which is totally untapped. We can use various kinds of craft to create contemporary utilitarian products. The USP would be the craft, unique from India. I had recently worked with Kashmiri craftsmen with copper and walnut. One of the products designed was a tea set made from hand beaten copper with a dash of motifs. The set could be aesthetic in any setting. The Indian design or appeal comes from the minimal use of traditional work." As Gupta says, "There are two sections of Indian designers today, one, which is creating contemporary global designs without much cues from India and another, creating products using traditional craft skills to create contemporary designs."

Bimla Verma

It is these interpretations, applications and innovations, which are going to decide Indian design in the days to come. The focus for the future would be on materials, skills and how best can this vast treasure trove of inspiration that is India is adapted to create a new genre of new designs. The Samsung Friendship Cup is a point in that direction, inspired by peace and friendship, the use of gold and silver metal connoting the two nations. Thumbs shaped like dove heralding the peace process and the cricket ball connoting the game. Sogani's words seem almost prophetic; "The profession is kicking and will be a critical field in the years to come." ◆